

acceptance was not indicative of the general quality of the association's other 24,179 members. Mr. Williams insisted there is little chance another dog would get into the IAFP, though he did admit that whoever sends in the \$125 and fills out all the questions is given the full benefit of the doubt. He reminded me that the IAFP is a trade association, not a licensing bureau.

I also phoned the Institute of Certified Financial Planners in Denver, Colorado, affiliated with the College for Financial Planning, to find out about their CFP exam. The person I talked to, who must have been a secretary, told me the CFP exam is the culmination of a six-part course that can be studied at home. Two thousand new planners passed it in the most recent year. She also volunteered that the CFP is a lot harder than the ChFC. To check this, I called the ChFC people at the American College for chartered financial consultants of Bryn Mawr, Pennsylvania. They said their ChFC test is an offshoot of the older CLU for chartered life underwriters and, if anything, is harder than the CFP.

Finally, I contacted the National Association of Personal Financial Advisors, which represents a special category of professionals who charge a fixed yearly fee for services. The NAPFA has no exam, and can be joined for \$120 a year. To its knowledge, it hadn't accepted any dogs.)

After describing the financial universe, Mr. Leffert began to explain some of the things financial planning could do for me. The most important was to "help clarify my financial objectives." I thought these were pretty clear already, especially after those nights I'd spent watching late-night television. "I want to get rich. That's my objective," I told Mr. Leffert. He laughed, as if this were a joke! When I didn't laugh back, he got a disturbed look on his face and subsequently took on a more patronizing attitude toward my case.

If you visit a financial planner, I'd advise you not to mention that getting rich is one of your objectives. They seem to have a taboo against this. Mr. Leffert, at least, seemed more interested in helping me move around what I already had than in helping me get more of it. Also, if I were you, I wouldn't mention "blowing it on a whim," "painting the town red," "a little bit of lucre buys a lot of things," "big bangs for the buck," "easy come, easy go,"